then, human relationships and financial transactions that were more humdrum and repetitive made a crucial difference. Imperialism advanced by combining all of this effectively. But today, the latter two are more potent in the penetration of societies through the course of normal activities and in creating options, leaving it to be decided when and whether they are to be exercised.

The most underestimated concerns are, therefore, what take place as routine in daily life. From the security perspective, globalization should be assessed for the interpenetration and interdependence that it embodies. And that, in turn, underlines that distance is no longer a safeguard. After all, we have all discovered that self-radicalization can happen without leaving home. Globalization has not only brought the world to our doorstep, it has also carried the accompanying opportunities and anxieties with it. The more technology-centric our life becomes, the more serious the challenges will be.

Even as this spectrum of vulnerability widens, our expectation of what constitutes adequate protection is also expanding. National security was traditionally viewed largely in narrow military, policing and legal terms, highlighting the assumption that threats were both far away and well-defined. But neither hold true any longer. Furthermore, experiences of dependence and pressure, such as of technology and finance, as also of food or fuel, have rekindled a global debate on the merits of strategic autonomy. Bringing economic security to the heart of national security has been facilitated by the rise of China, the changed American discourse, impact of Covid, the Ukraine conflict and the Middle East violence. It has given more weight to livelihood concerns as opposed to profitability considerations.

This steady expansion of what impinges on collective comfort levels has added sharper edges to every nation’s calculation. Indeed, disruption itself has become the driver for constantly evolving definitions of security. The value that partnerships and cooperative arrangements now offer as reassurance has increased in value.

Changes are not just structural; they can also be behavioural. We must recognize the inflection points of the last two decades in this context. These include the 2008 global financial crisis and changed leadership styles in many power centres. It continues all the way to the Covid pandemic and the Ukraine conflict. All in all, we are seeing heightened competition in global politics led by major powers. There is less questioning now when nations